

World in Brief: America due to unveil sanctions on Iran; Zelensky says elections would “destroy” Ukraine



Photograph: EPA

Scott Bessent is expected to unveil new sanctions against **Iran** on Monday. America's treasury secretary promised “the single greatest financial offensive ever marshaled against an adversary.” Donald Trump has recently **threatened** sanctions against Iran's trading partners. Meanwhile, Pakistan's army chief, Asim Munir (pictured), will visit Tehran in an attempt to mediate an end to the war. China said it was “actively committed to promoting peace talks”.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine's** president, said that **holding wartime elections** would “destroy” his country by sowing division. Last week Mykhailo Fedorov, a former defence minister whose dismissal last month sparked widespread protests, called for a vote. On Monday Mr Zelensky will get some support from Andy Burnham, who is visiting Kyiv for his first foreign trip as Britain's prime minister.

Shein started book-building for its much-delayed initial public offering in Hong Kong. It will seek to raise HK\$13.9bn (\$1.8bn). The Chinese fast-fashion firm could achieve a valuation of \$27bn, far below the \$98bn it reached in 2022. Weak global growth, rising costs (including those related to American tariffs) and intensifying

competition are to blame. Shares will start trading on September 1st.

Mr Trump said that **Canada** wanted the “benefits of being a State, without being one” after trade talks between America and Canada collapsed. Earlier Mark Carney, Canada’s prime minister, said his country would retaliate “dollar for dollar” against [America’s new 50% tariffs](#), with its own levies taking effect on September 8th. Mr Trump announced the measures on Friday after negotiations broke down.

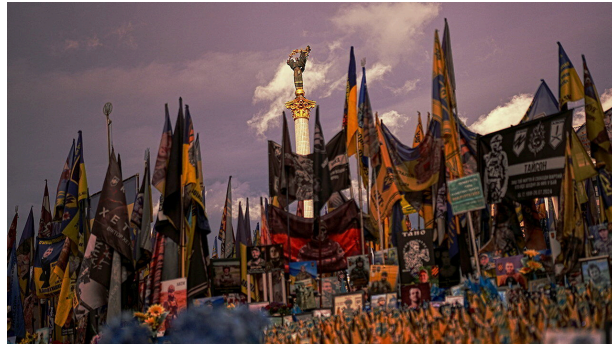
Alibaba’s stock price fell by nearly 9% after it announced it would issue new shares at a sharp discount to raise funds for its [AI business](#). The Chinese tech giant could make up to HK\$80bn (\$10.2bn) from the issue. Investors worried that issuing cheaper new stock would reduce the value of their existing holdings.

A party led by allies of [Kassym-Jomart Tokayev](#), **Kazakhstan’s** strongman president, won a parliamentary **election**. No genuine opposition party was on the ballot and critics were arrested during the campaign. Hours before the results were released, Mr Tokayev hinted that he may stay in power beyond his current term, which ends in 2029.

Australia confirmed its first case of **avian influenza** (H5N1) in a mammal, having detected [the virus](#) in a long-nosed fur seal. The virus, which is deadly to birds, has devastated flocks since it emerged in the country in June. Seals are particularly vulnerable to transmission from seabirds.

Figure of the day: 12.66 metres per second, the running speed clocked up by Superman on August 17th. That is impressive, but China will struggle to make money from humanoid robots. [Read why](#).

A sombre birthday for Ukraine



Photograph: AP

Ukraine celebrates its 35th independence day on Monday, but few locals are in the mood for a party. It has been 12 years since Russia began its war, and more than four since it launched a full-scale invasion. Tens of thousands of Ukrainians are dead, millions have fled and 20% of the country is occupied.

However, this year Ukraine has defied the odds and regained battlefield momentum. Developments in drone and missile technology have enabled it to [bring the war home to Russians](#), particularly with strikes on e-commerce hubs. But now Ukraine is running out of interceptors; Russian attacks are [severely harming its economy and military prospects](#). On Monday Ukraine's coalition of the willing—a group of supportive countries—is meeting; allies will probably pledge more military support. (On Saturday France promised to send more interceptors.) That may give Ukrainians more to celebrate.

Tensions rise in the occupied West Bank



Photograph: Reuters

Violence between Israeli settlers and Palestinians continued to escalate in the occupied West Bank over the weekend. On Friday a Palestinian teenager was killed and an elderly man severely wounded when a group of settlers raided a village near Hebron. The following night an arson attack occurred in a village near Nablus; nationalist graffiti suggests settlers were to blame. On Sunday morning an Israeli was stabbed and wounded in the Jordan Valley.

Settlers' stated aim is to cause "friction" with adjacent Palestinian villages. That tends to lead to intervention by the Israel Defence Forces, often on the settlers' side, followed by the expulsion of Palestinians and the expansion of Israeli settlements. The IDF has been slow to rein in the settlers, who have the government's support. In recent weeks Israeli security officials have repeatedly warned that settlers want to [provoke a new intifada](#) (Palestinian uprising), which would lead to the IDF entering Palestinian cities. That would bring even more violence and misery to the West Bank's embattled Palestinians.

Rochdale trial restarts



Photograph: Getty Images

This week the retrial of six alleged members of the Rochdale grooming gang begins in Manchester. The men deny raping and abusing two teenage girls between 2003 and 2006. The first trial collapsed in December after jurors, who had been ordered not to talk about the case outside court or to conduct independent research, were found to have set up a WhatsApp group in which they discussed a documentary on the topic.

Britain's grooming-gangs scandal—the long-ignored group-based sexual abuse of children by mostly Asian or Muslim (especially Pakistani) men—has rolled on for 20 years. Police failed to record suspects' ethnicity out of fear of appearing racist or upsetting community relations (they only began doing so last year). Investigations were badly botched. Following [a damning audit](#) published last year, a national inquiry is under way and hundreds of cold cases have been reopened. More trials are expected.

Donald, diamonds and denials



Photograph: David Gotlib via AP

Gaudy and gilded gifts are the way to Donald Trump's heart. A Qatari jumbo jet aside, few have been quite as ostentatious as a piece of jewellery Mr Trump received from representatives of Belgium's diamond industry in June. The watch-sized ring is studded with 321 diamonds, 56 sapphires, 13 emeralds and six rubies. Diamonds spell out two giant "T"s and the numbers 45 and 47 (Mr Trump is America's 45th and 47th president). Four weeks after receiving the present, Mr Trump approved a tariff exemption worth billions of dollars to Belgium's diamond industry.

Now Elizabeth Warren and Richard Blumenthal, two Democratic senators, are demanding answers about the gift. The ring's manufacturers have until Monday to explain themselves to Congress. The Trump administration and Belgium's diamond industry deny any special favours, claiming that the tariff exemption goes back to a trade agreement signed with the European Union in 2025. Diamonds are made under pressure; this week the ring's makers will feel some of their own.

Women's basketball becomes embroiled in the culture wars



Photograph: AP

As the [Women's National Basketball Association](#) enters the final stretch of its season, there is drama on and off the court. The league has become a battleground in America's culture wars. Much of the focus has been on Sophie Cunningham of the Indiana Fever, who has said transgender women should be barred from women's sports. She has become a MAGA cause célèbre.

Right-wing commentators have seized on every twist in the story, from rallies outside arenas to fans showing up in shirts supporting Ms Cunningham's view. Race is part of it, too. WNBA players are mostly black; Ms Cunningham is white. So is Caitlin Clark, the league's biggest star. Republican lawmakers have complained that she is being pushed around by other players, suggesting that race is a factor.

Why are Republicans pushing these culture-war buttons now? As the midterms approach, voters are focused on affordability. But race and trans issues offer better terrain on which to portray Democrats as out of touch. Ms Clark's attitude is probably indicative of most players: "Our focus is on basketball."

*Nothing is built on stone; all is
built on sand, but we must build
as if the sand were stone.*

Jorge Luis Borges